

| By Sharda Ugra |

It was the end of a bruising, bloody round of hand-to-hand combat. For five days, Indian hockey players had fought inevitable powerlessness and officials in charge of the leftovers of a sport fast fading into farce. Then peace was finally brokered and calm reigned for a moment. The sport that offered India more tear-jerker material than a daily soap even wore a wan smile.

Then, after Suresh Kalmadi's impersonation of a slightly delayed Santa Claus, the grim reaper seemed to have arrived in the form of Harish Sharma, secretary-general of the Basketball Federation of India and an official of Hockey India's (HI) ad hoc committee. His message for the team that had "struck" training and struck their sport in the gut, was curt: "Now they have to perform in the World Cup. They must prove they all deserve whatever they were asking for."

On an atypical day for Indian hockey, when a team of 22 had scored an unexpected, euphoric goal over the establishment, it was a typical statement. Not that the Indian hockey player had demanded a Gulfstream jet, a Hugo Boss suit and an eight-figure salary. At the heart of HI's peeve was the mere act of the demand.

Indian hockey players rarely make even a request. Questions in themselves were quelled. Whether it was an attempt to nail the federation for cornering funds once split with players in 1985. Or setting up a player association in 1989-90. Or asking for a match fee after winning an Asian Games gold in 1998. KPS Gill, former IHF president and the sport's most heavy-handed autocrat, huffed with pride that in his time the current crisis would have been resolved in a day. Resolved, of course, by sacking players or breaking up the pack by arm-twisting a Punjab lobby.

The HI officials who never threatened the axe made a mistake when they marketed their adversaries to national television as a money-grub-

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Hockey players celebrate a rare triumph over officialdom, but all promises must be met



bing outfit rather than a group of athletes making a fairly reasonable series of demands: an incentive bonus that was due, a graded system of payments and a security cover of medical insurance. For a group that was given a daily allowance of \$14 a day during an event they won in Malaysia, words like, "money over national colours" was not rich, but just very rude.

The players' rebellion struck a chord at many levels: their moment,

seven weeks before a World Cup grabbed the attention of officials, sponsors, public and polity.

The manner in which they held their ground impressed other players, former and current, so much so that even the second-string Indian team pledged support. Playmaker Arjun Halappa, one of the six who had fronted the players for nearly 100 hours, said, "We learnt that if you stand united, everything is achievable."